



Bacteria

Bacteria are simple single-celled microbes. The largest bacteria are around half a millimeter long, but still only just visible with the naked eye. They are mainly spherical or rod-shaped, with longer rods sometimes twisted into spirals. Some species form chains, clusters, or dense mats. Bacteria can be useful or harmful.



YOGURT BACTERIA

Good bacteria turn milk into cheese and yogurt, treat sewage, help cows digest grass, and fix nitrogen in the soil.

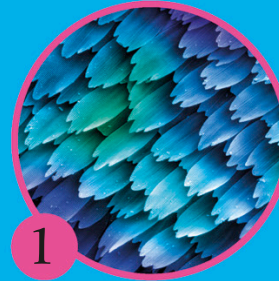


E. COLI BACTERIA

Bad bacteria cause diseases in animals and plants, contaminate water, and poison food.

MICRO QUIZ

Can you *guess* what these are? *Read the clues:*



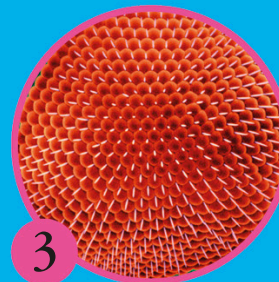
1

Beautifully colored scales help this insect fly and flutter. They usually look smooth and delicate.



2

If you get hayfever you may not like these, but plants couldn't reproduce without them.



3

Made up of hundreds of facets, this is a very useful organ. The tiny animal that uses it is hard to catch.



4

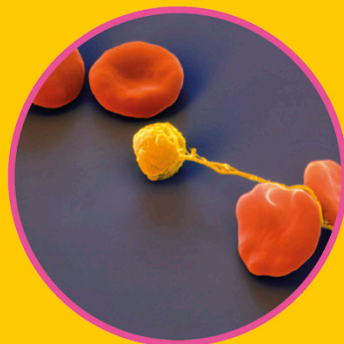
This shaft of dead and flattened cells helps protect us. It grows up to 0.3 mm every day.



5

Who would guess that these soft and delicate parts of a plant would look so bumpy close up?

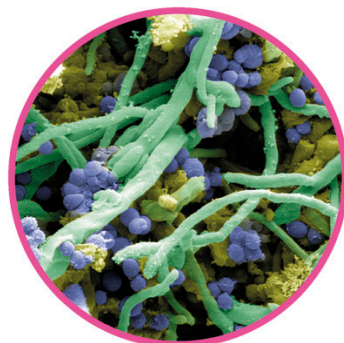
Answers: 1. Butterfly wing, 2. pollen grain, 3. fly eye, 4. human hair, 5. flower petal.



MALARIA PROTOZOAN

Protozoa

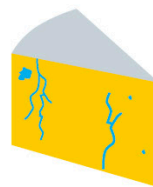
These are the most advanced form of microbes and belong to the protist kingdom. Many have features that are not found in bacteria, such as a whip-like tail, hairs, or foot-like projections (called pseudopods) that pull them along. They prey on bacteria, single-celled algae, and microfungi. Protozoa are also responsible for diseases such as malaria.



BLUE-CHEESE MOLD

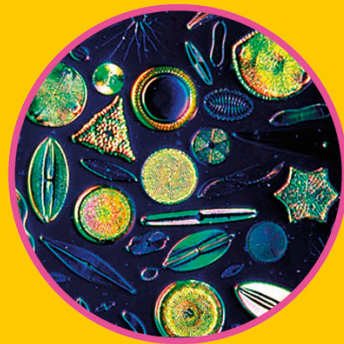
Fungi

Most people think of fungi as mushrooms but there are many other species that are too small to see. Some cause diseases such as athlete's foot or ringworm in humans or blight in plants. Yeasts are used to make bread and soy sauce, and molds make the blue veins in cheese. Fungi are also used to make antibiotics that kill bacteria.



Plankton

The majority of living organisms in the oceans today are bacteria. These, along with other microscopic animals, larvae, and plants, are known as plankton. They are concentrated in the well-lit surface layers of the oceans and provide food for larger animals. The name "plankton" comes from the Greek word for drifter, or wanderer, since the organisms drift along with the current.



PLANKTON

You can fit a million bacteria on a pin head.